



Flashing Bright

**Flash MX is more than just a Web animation tool—
it's a full-fledged development platform for creating content-rich Web sites and Web applications**

Flash MX is the first product to be released from Macromedia's new MX line-up. Macromedia's goal is to release a new suite of applications that will enable the development of next-generation Internet content. The MX tagline clearly indicates Macromedia's intention to tighten integration between its various products just like Microsoft 2000 and XP. There's a lot to like about Flash MX such as dockable and collapsible panels, revamped user interface features, expanded video capabilities, improved ActionScript editor and much more. But is it worth your time and money?

Interface and ease of use

Flash MX sports a familiar interface, with the only difference being the incorporation of the MX panel management system. For the first time, layers can be grouped and neatly arranged—you don't need to scroll the layers up and down, or reduce the work area size while working with huge animations which involve lots of layers. To make things even more convenient, every object can be easily distributed as different layers either through

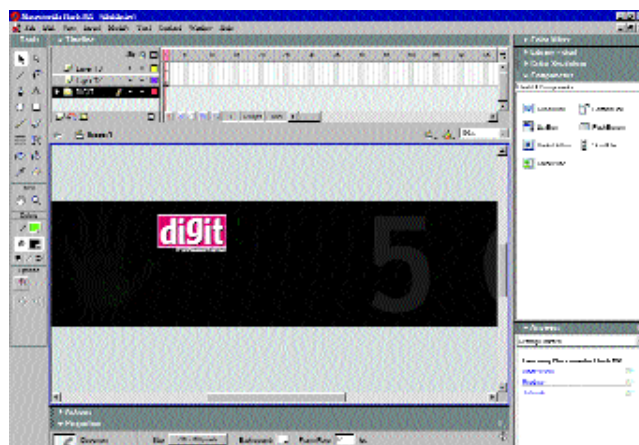
the menu, or by right-clicking on the object itself.

The timeline may seem unaltered at first glance, but you'll notice the differences once you start working with it. In order to select multiple frames, all you have to do is drag the slider across the timeline. With the MX panel management system, you can collapse the timeline to get even more space for the work area.

The back arrow on the timeline lets you go back to your previous working state instead of accessing it through the menu and the magnification option sits conveniently at the edge of the timeline. Knowing the various properties of the object you are working on is imperative. The Property inspector panel now sits on the work area itself, allowing you to change the various properties of the

object instantaneously. Since it shows only relevant, context-sensitive settings when you work, it dramatically reduces the number of panels open at any time.

Though the MX panel management has its advantages, it may not be convenient to some users—the panels slide up and down while accessing them, forcing you to adjust your focus accordingly, which



The revamped interface of Flash MX ensures greater ease of use and flexibility